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Graduate Capstone Project Plan

Portfolio Artifact Outline

1. Project Overview

Purpose

The purpose of the MLA Capstone project was to create an interdisciplinary final project that demonstrated the skills acquired via coursework as part of my Master's Program for McDaniel College. This document presents the planning and documentation process I used to develop my graduate capstone project.

I chose to research, outline and write a creative writing project about a politically and emotionally charged subject: gun violence in the United States. Specifically, I studied the societal reaction to school shootings as a way to understand government policy as well as cultural responses to mass violence.

This project presented an opportunity to demonstrate the skills and competencies I had developed over the course of my degree. To understand the topic, I conducted extensive research on the subjects which would appear in my eventual writing. I read and annotated numerous books to gather information and to analyze writing style. I documented this research and compiled it all into a detailed annotated bibliography and literature review. I created and reviewed a project plan with my program advisor. I documented the entire process in a standardized format to demonstrate mastery and progress for my advisor.

My final product took the form of a novel composed of short vignettes representing the numerous aspects that I researched. The style of stories varied from satirical critiques of the absurd and nonsensical responses to mass violence incidents as well as earnest and introspective pieces about the ways individuals cope with grief and loss.

This project required me to demonstrate competencies in project planning, content organization, research planning, as well as production scheduling and iterative revision. I started with a broad open ended project and created a structured production plan, and I executed this plan by meeting a defined production schedule and by incorporating feedback from my advisor.

2. Requirements & Deliverables

The program provided broad requirements but left the specific structure and deliverables largely to the student. I therefore translated those requirements into a concrete set of deliverables, deadlines, and review milestones. My final project was a collection of short interconnected vignettes that depict various reactions to school shootings in the United States.

Because the project required substantial independent research, I developed a literature review and annotated bibliography as part of the project plan. The source list was entirely self-selected, requiring me to identify, evaluate, and prioritize sources according to their relevance to the project's goals.

In total, I read and annotated eight novels of varying genres. I documented these by creating novel assessments every two weeks. These reviews discussed the strengths and weaknesses of each novel as well as how I planned to specifically use the knowledge from each in my final project.

I also conducted subject matter research and annotated an additional 10 sources ranging from in depth news reports to academic papers. The topics ranged from timelines and reports covering gun violence incidents to longitudinal studies analyzing data related to gun violence in the United States. This new research supplemented information I had already gathered and reviewed in prior courses, and ensured that the representation of my chosen subject was accurate.

Deliverable	Description	Completion Criteria	Timeline
Final Project - Collection of vignettes	A collection of 10 interconnected vignettes and one Epilogue that explore the aftermath of school shootings in the United States	- All stories revised following advisor feedback - Final manuscript submitted through McDaniel's Learning Management System (Blackboard)	Final manuscript completed and submitted by the end of 16 weeks
Story Drafts	- First drafts based on the approved project outline - Drafts submitted for advisor review - Revised drafts incorporate selected advisor feedback - Revisions documented using tracked changes and commentary	- Draft submitted by established deadline - Printed copy delivered to advisor - Revised draft submitted following feedback - Tracked changes and commentary included	2 first drafts every 2 weeks 2 revised copies submitted within 1 week of receiving revisions
Learning Logs	Informal reflections on the work completed during a one week period. ~300-500 words	- A word document emailed to my project advisor by the established deadline.	1 Per week submitted by midnight on Sunday
Bi-Weekly Reflection	- Formal reflections on the process of completing the assigned deadlines and creation of deliverables. - Self-assessment of strengths and identification of weaknesses. - Description of strategies to address weaknesses and deficiencies. ~500-800 Words	- A word document submitted to the appropriate location in Blackboard by the established deadline.	Every 2 weeks submitted by midnight on Sunday
Annotated Bibliography	- Formal academic assessment of the sources and books I annotated during the course of completing the project. - Assessment of author credibility, research methods, writing style, etc. Also includes a description of the utility for my final project.		Every 2 weeks submitted by midnight on Monday Any sources compiled and reviewed as part of the research process
Novel Assessment	- Academic report and review of the novels I read as part of the writing process. - Reflections assessed style, content, and utility of the selected novels ~1500-2000 words		1 Novel assessment every 2 weeks submitted by midnight on Wednesday

3. Content Architecture / Work Breakdown

Component	Purpose	Research
Satirical Story 1 — Gun Store	Examine commercial and political reactions to the shooting	Contemporary reporting, gun policy research
Satirical Story 2 — Donation	Examine performative charity and post-tragedy donations	Reporting on post Sandy Hook donations, United Way
Satirical Story 3 — Gifts	Examine the unintended consequences of overwhelming charitable response	<i>Sandy Hook</i>
Satirical Story 4 — Conspiracy Theorist	Examine the development of shooting-related conspiracy theories	InfoWars archives, interviews, trial materials, deposition videos
Satirical Story 5 — Juror	Examine the difficulty of assigning monetary value to harm	Trial/legal research
Earnest Story 1 — Reporter	Examine media behavior immediately after a shooting	Contemporary reporting Elizabeth Williamson - NYT Josh Kovner - Hartford Courant Anderson Cooper - CNN
Earnest Story 2 — Detective	Examine the behind-the-scenes work of those responsible for investigating the aftermath	<i>Sandy Hook</i> <i>Columbine</i> Detective Van Ness
Earnest Story 3 — Construction Worker	Explore the physical aftermath of the shooting and the process of removing the shooter's former home	<i>Sandy Hook</i> Josh Kovner Reporting
Earnest Story 4 — Teacher	Explore the experience of preparing teachers for the possibility of a school shooting and the emotional weight of that preparation	SRP Training <i>Columbine</i> Personal Experience
Earnest Story 5 — Pastor	Examine the role of religious leaders in responding to a community tragedy	<i>Sandy Hook</i> Josh Kovner Reporting David Cullen - Cassie Bernall coverage
Culminating Epilogue	Bring together the perspectives established throughout the collection while emphasizing the continuing and recurring nature of school shootings	All relevant sources Contemporary reporting on the Alex Jones trial

Satirical Stories - Outlines/Brief Ideas

Story 1 — Gun Store

- A gun-store employee observes a line of customers purchasing ammunition after the shooting.
- A customer purchases the type of gun used in the shooting.
- The shopkeeper asks why the customer wants that particular model.
- The customer identifies the connection to the shooting.
- Explore the relationship between tragedy and gun sales.
- Address fears among Second Amendment supporters that the firearm may be banned.

Story 2 — Donation

- A person in another part of the United States hears about the shooting.
- The person decides to send a donation.
- The character agonizes over how much money to donate.
- Explore the desire to appear compassionate without appearing cheap.
- The character ultimately donates to a scammer posing as a relative organizing a funeral.

Story 3 — Gifts

- A person in the affected town observes the large quantity of gifts and donations arriving after the shooting.
- Explore the eventual disposal of those gifts.
- Draw on the treatment of donated materials described in Williamson's *Sandy Hook*.
- Include toys and other gifts collected in bins and skiffs.
- Emphasize the physical deterioration of the gifts in mud, dirt, and rain.

Story 4 — Conspiracy Theorist

- Follow Max Blackwood, a conspiracy theorist/radio or internet personality.
- Establish his coverage of the shooting over several days.
- Show his initial attempt to use the shooting to advocate for gun rights.
- Have Max begin promoting the idea that the shooting was staged.
- Draw on the Anderson Cooper/Veronique Posner interview as a source/model for the scenario.

Story 5 — Juror

- Follow a juror determining damages in Max's eventual defamation trial.
- Connect the story thematically to the earlier donation story.
- Explore the question of how much monetary compensation is appropriate.
- Explore the problem of assigning a monetary value to a human life.
- Examine the absurdity of calculating damages in the context of an event of enormous historical and human significance.

Earnest Stories - Outlines/Brief Ideas

Story 1 — Reporter

- Follow a news reporter attempting to interview a neighbor.
- Give the neighbor narcissistic motivations for participating.
- Show the neighbor's desire to be associated with a major disaster.
- Have the neighbor provide information that is useless or actively harmful.
- Include conspiratorial thinking in the interview.
 - Neighbor eventually calls into Max Blackwood's show and reports what he thinks is going on. Seeds Conspiracy theories.
- Have the reporter realize that none of the information can responsibly be used.
- End with the reporter writing an Op-Ed in the paper.

Story 2 — Detective

- Follow Detective Sarah Morgan.
- Depict the detective working quietly and solemnly behind the scenes.
- Focus on serving the families and having difficulty with investigative responsibilities.
 - Returning personal items becomes a primary focus for her.
- Base aspects of the character/work on detective Van Ness.
- End with her washing and drying the jackets recovered from the scene in the basement of the barracks.

Story 3 — Construction Worker

- Follow a construction worker involved in demolishing the shooter's house.
 - The house is virtually empty, but there are still small signs of the shooter's presence. The investigating team has already come through and removed things.
- Base the situation on the destruction of Lanza's home.
 - All items inside are to be incinerated.

- Explore the idea of the property eventually being reclaimed by the surrounding woods.

Story 4 — Teacher

- Follow a teacher participating in pre-service training about school shooting safety protocols.
- Draw on my own personal experience.
- Focus on the instruction to tie a knot around a doorknob.
- Include the safety instructor teaching teachers how to tie a slipknot.
 - His tone is upbeat and sardonic, which clashes with the somber tone of the room.

Story 5 — Pastor

- Follow a pastor preparing a sermon for the Sunday after the shooting.
- Unable to find the words/passages to discuss.
- Explore the pastor's preparation and uncertainty.
- Many of the victims were members of the congregation. He can't face their empty seats on Sunday.

Culminating Epilogue

- Set the epilogue ten years after the tragedy.
- Revisit the characters from the preceding stories.
- Examine how each character responds to a landmark outcome/anniversary event.
- Use the epilogue to bring together the perspectives established throughout the collection.
- End with the solemn and poignant reality that there will be more of these in the future.

4. Research Plan

This research plan connected specific sources to individual stories and used both historical research and literary models to inform my writing. Historical sources provided factual context for the fictionalized scenarios, while literary works served as models for narrative structure, tone, perspective, characterization, and the treatment of historical events. I also distinguished between information drawn from historical sources, techniques drawn from literary models, and material based on my own personal experience.

Primary Historical Research

- Research the Sandy Hook shooting.
- Use official reports.
- Review contemporary news coverage.
- Review Alex Jones's coverage from archival footage.
- Research reports from the period immediately following the shooting through approximately one year afterward.
- Review trial materials.
- Review transcripts.
- Review depositions.
- Review misinformation/conspiracy coverage, including relevant InfoWars episodes.

Literary Research / Models of Writing Style

Sandy Hook — Elizabeth Williamson

- Re-read the book with particular passages identified for specific stories.
- Chapters 7, 8, and 9:
 - Inform Satirical Story 5.
- Chapters 5 and 18:
 - Inform the epilogue.
- Chapters 1–4:
 - Inform the earnest stories.
- Chapter 2:
 - Inform Satirical Stories 2 and 4.

Catch-22 — Joseph Heller

- Study the use of satirical vignettes.
- Examine how a fictional setting can be used to explore a deadly serious real world situation.
- Study Heller's treatment of absurdity.
- Focus particularly on Chapters 8, 9, 11, 17, 18, 22, 31, 36, and 41.

Libra — Don DeLillo

- Study the treatment of a true historical event through historical fiction.
- Examine the use of multiple perspectives.
- Study the non-linear approach to storytelling.
- Examine how extensive research can support fictionalized historical material.
- Use the investigative approach as a model for the detective story.

As I Lay Dying — William Faulkner

- Study the use of multiple perspectives.
- Examine how distinct characters can participate in the same overarching story.
- Consider how different narrative voices contribute to characterization.

Homegoing — Yaa Gyasi

- Study the use of multiple perspectives.
- Examine the approach to connecting individual stories within a larger narrative.

On the Management of Grief — Bharati Mukherjee

- Study the treatment of grief following a mass-casualty event.
- Examine how an individual character experiences loss following a terrorist attack.

Atonement — Ian McEwan

- Study the use of multiple perspectives.
 - Examine approaches to structuring a narrative around differing perspectives.
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5. 16-Week Production Schedule

Phase	Weeks	Primary Activities	Deliverables / Milestones
1. Research & Initial Outlining	1–2	Research the Newtown Elementary School shooting; review official reports, contemporary news reports, and Jones's coverage; re-read <i>Sandy Hook</i> and identify passages relevant to planned stories; outline story beats for Earnest Stories 1, 3, 4, and 5.	Initial research collection and initial story outlines.
2. Research & Outlining	2–4	Research reports covering the shooting through one year afterward; re-read <i>Catch-22</i> ; study selected satirical vignettes; outline Satirical Stories 1, 2, and 3.	Expanded research collection and additional story outlines.
3. Research & Outlining	5–6	Listen to relevant InfoWars episodes; review depositions; watch and read trial transcripts; outline Satirical Stories 4 and 5.	Research materials concerning misinformation, conspiracy theories, and the legal aftermath. Completed outlines for remaining satirical stories.
4. Research & Outlining	7–8	Outline Earnest Story 2; re-read <i>Libra</i> ; study the detective/investigative approach; compare Van Ness's work with the investigative structures in <i>Libra</i> .	Completed remaining story outline. Finalized research and planning materials.
5. Drafting	9–10	Draft Satirical Stories 1–3; read <i>Atonement</i> as a literary model; submit drafts to advisor for review and critique; begin drafting the next section while awaiting or receiving feedback.	Drafts of Satirical Stories 1–3 for advisor feedback.

6. Drafting	11–12	Draft Satirical Stories 5–6; read <i>On the Management of Grief</i> and <i>As I Lay Dying</i> ; submit drafts to advisor for review and critique.	Drafts of Satirical Stories 4–5 for advisor feedback. Revise and resubmit Satirical Stories 1–3 based on advisor feedback
7. Drafting	13–14	Draft Earnest Stories 1–3; read <i>Homegoing</i> ; submit drafts to advisor for review and critique.	Drafts of Earnest Stories 1–2 for advisor feedback.
8. Final Drafting & Compilation	15–16	Draft Earnest Stories 4–5; draft the culminating epilogue; compile previous stories and chapters; submit drafts for final advisor review and critique; assemble the final product.	Completed Earnest Stories 3–4. Completed epilogue. Compiled final manuscript. Final advisor review. Completed project.

6. Skills Demonstrated

Ultimately, this project required me to take a complex, open-ended assignment and transform it into a structured and manageable production process. I defined project requirements, established discrete deliverables, organized content, planned and evaluated research, developed a production workflow and timeline, incorporated review milestones, and delivered a completed final product. Through this process, I developed transferable skills in technical writing, documentation, content development, information organization, research planning, and project coordination that can be applied to professional documentation and other complex content-development projects.

Requirements Analysis

- Interpreted broad graduate-program requirements.
- Converted academic requirements into specific project components.
- Established a concrete final format.
- Defined the scope of the project around a collection of interconnected stories.

Project Scoping

- Broke a large creative project into individual stories and an epilogue.
- Established two major content categories:
 - Satirical.
 - Earnest.
- Defined individual narrative objectives for each component.
- Established a finite 16-week production period.

Information Architecture

- Organized the project hierarchically.
- Divided the overall project into major components.
- Broke individual stories into smaller narrative beats.
- Created relationships between individual stories through recurring themes and ideas.
- Organized research materials according to their intended use.

Research Planning

- Identified different categories of research.
- Matched research materials to specific project components.
- Distinguished historical research from literary models.
- Planned research activities before drafting began.
- Used source material to establish the foundation for fictionalized content.

Workflow Design

- Sequenced research, outlining, drafting, review, and compilation.
- Established milestones.
- Built advisor review into the production process.
- Planned to begin subsequent work while previous material was undergoing review.

Iterative Review & Revision

- Planned multiple advisor-review cycles.
- Incorporated critique into the drafting workflow.
- Treated the project as an iterative process rather than a single drafting event.
- Reserved the final phase for compilation and completion.